FLASHPOINTS & FRAMEWORKS

THE LESSON THAT NEVER LANDS

Military force can suppress an insurgency's symptoms. It cannot resolve its causes.

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There is a recurring pattern in how states respond to armed insurgencies. The initial instinct is to reach for military tools: airstrikes, surge operations, elite counterterrorism units, or, as has become common in the Sahel, foreign paramilitary contractors. That instinct is not irrational. Governments face real violence, and they are expected to protect territory and population. The problem is not that military force is deployed. The problem is that it is deployed as a strategy rather than as one instrument within a larger political effort. When force substitutes for governance, negotiation, and structural reform, it does not end insurgencies. It sustains them.

The evidence for this is not theoretical. It is decades deep and geographically broad.

In Afghanistan, the United States invested nearly two decades of combat operations and appropriated $145 billion for reconstruction, including more than $36 billion specifically designated for governance, social, and economic development.[1] The Afghan security forces that were built, equipped, and trained at enormous cost collapsed within weeks of the American withdrawal in August 2021.[2] The Taliban, by contrast, had spent those years building governance structures across rural areas under their control, establishing courts, taxing trade, and providing dispute resolution where the state had failed to reach.[3] The insurgency won not because it outgunned the government, but because it outgoverned it in the places that mattered. The lesson that the U.S. government struggled to absorb across four administrations was documented plainly by its own auditors: rather than develop a coherent approach to legitimacy, the United States banked on resources and military presence alone.[4]

The same structural logic is now playing out in the Sahel, in real time.

Mali's military junta, which came to power promising rapid security gains, has invested heavily in Russian Africa Corps forces and drone capabilities. The International Crisis Group assessed in 2025 that the three military governments of Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger have treated conflict as a predominantly military matter, investing in foreign contractors and kinetic assets to the exclusion of

political dialogue with insurgents or meaningful governance reforms.[5] The results have been inverse to the stated ambition. Security conditions have continued to deteriorate. JNIM, the al-Qaeda affiliated coalition operating across the region, has extended its reach from rural strongholds into urban pressure points, imposing a fuel blockade in September 2025 that effectively strangled Bamako's economy.[6] The April 2026 coordinated offensive against multiple Malian cities, including strikes near the capital itself, demonstrated that a sustained kinetic campaign backed by an external military partner had not degraded the insurgency's capacity to mount complex, large-scale operations.[7] It had, if anything, provided the insurgency with a clearer political narrative: that the junta served foreign interests rather than Malian ones.

This pattern recurs across case after case because insurgencies are not primarily military phenomena. They are political and social ones. An armed group that sustains itself through years or decades of conflict is drawing on something the state has failed to provide: security, justice, inclusion, economic access, or identity recognition. Destroying the group's fighters does not eliminate the conditions that generate recruits. In Nigeria, aerial counterinsurgency operations targeting Boko Haram and ISWAP have repeatedly caused civilian harm, eroding the public trust that effective counterinsurgency depends on and expanding the pool of grievance from which armed groups recruit.[8] The Nigerian military's claims that civilian casualties were incidental failed to address the systemic intelligence failures driving the pattern. The operational logic was sound. The strategic logic was not.

The core problem is institutional. Military establishments are trained to solve military problems. They measure success through enemy casualties, territory controlled, and operational tempo. These are legitimate metrics for combat. They are poor metrics for political legitimacy. And in counterinsurgency, legitimacy is the decisive variable. States that win against insurgencies do not do so by killing their way to stability. They do so by becoming more credible than the insurgency in the eyes of the population.[9] That requires governance that reaches beyond capital cities, justice systems that function for ordinary people, and political processes that give excluded communities a stake in the state's survival.

The structural pressures that generate insurgencies do not disappear when a leader is killed or a camp is destroyed. They recompose around new leadership, new grievances, and new narratives. The War on Terror, begun in 2001, is still ongoing. The Taliban governed Afghanistan within weeks of the Western withdrawal. JNIM is more capable and geographically extensive in 2026 than it was in 2017, when it formed from a merger of smaller groups, each of which had survived prior military campaigns against them.[7]

None of this suggests that military force has no role. It does. Protecting civilians, degrading imminent threats, and creating space for political processes are legitimate military functions. The failure is not in deploying force. It is in treating force as a solution to problems it cannot solve. States that conflate tactical gains with strategic progress are not learning from experience. They are repeating it under different flags.

My question posed at the beginning of this piece asks when nation states will learn. The more precise question is whether the institutional incentives that govern security policy allow for learning at all. Defense budgets reward kinetic capability. Political cycles reward visible action. Negotiating with armed groups carries domestic political risk. Investing in governance reform produces results over years, not news cycles. The architecture of state decision-making consistently favors the tool that produces visible short-term activity over the structural work that produces durable stability.

Until that changes, the lesson will continue not to land.

What changes it is not rhetorical persuasion. It is consistent institutional accountability for long-run outcomes, not just short-run activity; independent assessment of security conditions over time, not government press releases; and leadership willing to measure success not by how many operations were launched but by whether the conditions that generated the insurgency have actually changed.

The pattern described here is not fixed. Insurgencies have ended through political settlements, governance reforms, and genuine inclusion of previously excluded groups. These outcomes are achievable. They require accepting that armed conflict is a symptom of political failure, and that the treatment for a political failure is a political solution.

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